



Urban Divide

City-wise break-up of male responses show how regional preferences differ

DO YOU WANT YOUR BRIDE TO BE FAIR AND BEAUTIFUL?



The fetish for fair skin is greatest among men in Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh and Andhra Pradesh; Gujarat is the least hung up on fairness, with about 47 per cent saying "it doesn't matter"

WILL YOU SHIFT BASE IF YOUR PARTNER NEEDS TO MOVE OUT?



Ahmedabad and Chennai men don't mind going that extra mile for their partner, with nearly 20 per cent in both cities saying "yes"; Kolkata and Delhi men most reluctant (about 13 per cent)

DO YOU BELIEVE CASTE TO BE A VITAL PARAMETER IN MATCHMAKING?



Delhi is the most flexible with over 58 per cent saying caste does not matter; Kerala appears to be pretty fixated on caste (26 per cent). Karnataka is bang in the middle (40 per cent)

DOES SPENDING TIME WITH BOTH FAMILIES HELP IN KNOWING EACH OTHER?



The homely blokes of Rajasthan (58 per cent), followed by Kerala and Andhra Pradesh think so. Individualistic West Bengal and Delhi believe in spending time with each other.

ARE YOU LOOKING FOR A PARTNER FROM YOUR CITY?



"Not necessarily," say about 69 per cent men in Pune, followed by those in Mumbai. Hyderabad men least inclined to look for a partner outside their known territory (43 per cent)

DO YOU WISH TO LIVE IN A JOINT FAMILY SET-UP?



Gujarati men seem to be the biggest home-bodies (69 per cent) and Kerala the least (44 per cent). Chennai men and women seem to be most in sync on this (46-47 per cent)

job stability, private sector workers or the self-employed for a better lifestyle.

So beauty is passé, age doesn't matter so much and working wives are ever more in demand. Good news for the modern woman, surely? Not really. Ask around and the reflection on the male mirror is of a woman exuding intangible virtues—loving, mature, cooperative, compassionate, responsible and understanding. In other words, men are seeking a soulmate. "We notice a fundamental shift in the preference for attributes and virtues, with compatibility emerging as the primary evaluation criterion among men," says Mittal.

Think of Ajay Jain, a 29-year-old businessman from Delhi. He never believed in man-made differences like caste, stars, planets, religion or language. And now, after his beloved wife died in a freak accident, he is now simply looking for a normal girl who would be frank, honest and understand his past. Beyond that he doesn't have a problem with anything—a working

wife or a homemaker, divorced or unmarried. "Marriage is not a job. And relationships don't depend on external parameters."

But the image of the modern woman that appears on that male mirror, rightly or not, is often of a materialistic, grasping creature, who conveniently negotiates from behind parental apron strings, places innumerable conditions before marriage and promptly moves on to the "most suitable" candidate, if needs be. Consider Hosur: he believes, he is helpful to a fault and was once ditched by a girl precisely because of this. Now he is looking for someone who is "spiritual" and would understand him. "It's maturity that I seek," he says. Ask Anarkat. He got divorced within a month of marriage and now says: "It made me realise all I need is a normal, grounded girl, with whom my chemistry will click." To him, trendy clothes don't make a modern woman. "It's someone who knows how to adjust with the times." Krishna is looking for someone who is intelligent, inde-

AJAY JAIN, 29, Businessman, DELHI

A personal tragedy has given him a philosophical take on life. He never believed in caste, stars and planets. And now he is looking for a simple girl who would be frank, honest, understand him and his past. Beyond that he doesn't have a problem with anything—a working wife or a homemaker, divorced or unmarried, modern or traditional.

"My wife can do anything, be anything. After all, marriage is not a job."



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